

Welcome back to my series of short lectures on apes. Today we will examine recent and historical breakthroughs on the behavior of chimpanzees, otherwise known as chimps.

The word chimpanzee is an umbrella term for two different species of apes in the genus pan, which are the common chimpanzee or pan troglodytes, found in western central Africa and the bonobo or pan paniscus, which are found in the forests of the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

Chimpanzees belong to the hominidae family together with gorillas, orangutans and indeed, humans. Current research tells us that the chimps broke away from the human branch of the hominid family. A problem at least 6 million years ago and remained the closest living relative to humans to this day.

More modern researches into chimpanzees have centered on their behavioral characteristics. Once all biological and genetic factors have been ruled out in this way, scientists have under the influence of a similar tease between human and chimpanzee behavior. Although much of this research has taken place through observation of captive chimps, the results are widely seen as an authoritative reflection of chimps living in the wild.

Chimps live in large so called communities, comprised of many male and female members with the social hierarchy determined by an individual chimps position and influence through such research. Scientists have found that chimps learn and adapt through observation of others behavior.

Once in power, the Alpha male is often seen to alter its body language in order to retain power. For example, he might puff himself up in order to intimidate others. While lower ranking chimps are noted to behave more submissively and holding out their hands while grunting.

Female chimpanzees also have a distinct social hierarchy with high social standing inherited by children. It is not unheard of for a dominant female to unite and overthrow the Alpha male backing another in his place. James Diamond. In his book, *The Third Chimpanzee* suggests that chimps should now be reclassified in the genus homo instead of pan. And there are many arguments still in favor of this.

Male common chimpanzees are, on average 1.7 meters in height, weighing 70 kilograms with their female counterparts being somewhat smaller. By comparison, the bonobo is slightly shorter and lighter, but with longer arms and legs. However, both species walk on all fours and climb trees with great ease.

Jane Goodall made a groundbreaking discovery in 1960. When she observed the use of tools among chimpanzees, including digging for termites with large sticks. A recent

study claimed to reveal that common chimpanzees in Senegal have been using spears sharpened with their teeth to hunt. However, these reports remain unsubstantiated. Researchers have witnessed such tools, namely rocks being used by chimps to open coconut shells and indeed crushing nuts with stone hammers as scientific technology has developed. So too, has our knowledge of the sheer extent of the chimps. Intelligence research has now shown that chimps have the capability to learn and use symbols and understand aspects of the human language, including syntax, as well as numerical sequences.

As I mentioned earlier, the umbrella term chimpanzee is comprised of the common chimpanzee and the bonobo. These two sub species are divided along the Congo river with the common chimps living on one side and the bonobos living on the opposite side of the river. Over the past few decades, both of these sub species have witness to alarming decrease in population density with animal activists now working harder than ever to protect those remaining and encourage procreation.